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Gavin Newsom and Lawmakers to Begin Work to 'Trump-Proof' California Laws

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Democratic Governor Gavin Newsom of California and other state lawmakers will meet on Monday to protect the state's progressive policies ahead of President-elect Donald Trump's presidency.

Convening a special session at the state's capitol on Monday, Newsom is asking his Democratic allies in the Legislature, who hold supermajorities in both chambers, to approve additional funding to the attorney general's office to prepare for a legal fight amid expected federal challenges.

On Monday, Democratic Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel proposed allocating $25 million to bolster the attorney general's office for legal defenses. This fund aims to shield state policies on civil rights, climate initiatives, abortion rights, and immigration from anticipated federal pushback.

"While we always hope to collaborate with our federal partners, California will be ready to vigorously defend our interests and values from any unlawful action by the incoming Trump Administration," Gabriel said in a statement.

Contentious Relationships

During Trump's first presidency, California filed over 120 lawsuits against his administration, achieving varied levels of success.

However, Newsom remains steadfast in ensuring that history doesn't repeat itself without a fight.

"We're not going to be caught flat-footed," Newsom said at a recent news conference, emphasizing California's preparedness to counteract Trump's agenda.

Trump has spoken out against Newsom and California policies in the past. Labeling the governor "New-scum" during his 2020 campaign, Trump has criticized the state for its homelessness issues, environmental regulations and immigration policies. He has also threatened to withhold federal disaster aid and pledged mass deportations targeting undocumented immigrants.

Meanwhile, California Republicans have slammed the special session as a distraction. Assemblymember Vince Fong from the Central Valley accused Newsom of being out of touch, urging collaboration with federal authorities rather than confrontation.

A Broader Legislative Agenda

In an effort to counter potential federal rollbacks, Newsom is considering measures like reinstating electric vehicle purchase rebates and creating a disaster relief fund to cushion against federal funding cuts.

Attorney General Rob Bonta echoed the administration's commitment to defending immigrant populations and other vulnerable groups.

In addition, the special session coincides with the swearing-in of new legislators and discussions on safeguarding laws related to abortion access and environmental mandates, including California's groundbreaking 2035 electric vehicle target.

While lawmakers aim to ensure funding is in place before Inauguration Day on January 20, looming budget deficits

pose challenges with the state projecting a $2 billion shortfall next year.

According to officials, the state spent roughly $42 million in litigation costs during the first Trump administration.

Nevertheless, Democratic lawmakers remain undeterred, citing past legal victories, such as reclaiming millions in federal funds through lawsuits against the Trump administration.

Gabriel, who sued the first Trump administration in 2017 when it tried to end a program to shield young immigrants from being deported, said lining up the funding now is "a wise investment."

"We are positioned, if necessary, to be the tip of the spear of the resistance and to push back against any unlawful or unconstitutional actions by the Trump administration," Gabriel, who chairs the budget committee, said, according to The Associated Press.

This article includes reporting from The Associated Press.

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